because the all-male committee at the Film Federation of India felt Kapadia's film did not feel like "Indian cinema". Kapadia admits she's "confused" by the reasoning: "Maybe it's a technical thing, since the producers are French."

THE ARTFUL STORYTELLER

All We Imagine... would have made a strong contender, for it is an affecting and alluring drama about three women in Mumbai. Prabha (Kani Kusruti) and Anu (Divya Prabha) are Malayali nurses; Prabha is in a limbo waiting for a husband who hasn't communicated since he moved to Germany, while Anu is in a clandestine relationship with a Muslim boy, one she knows will never meet her parents' approval. Meanwhile, Parvati (Chhaya Kadam), lacking "documents", loses her home in the city and is forced to move back to her village home by the sea in Ratnagiri. Shot with a dreamlike vibe, Mumbai's local trains, markets and hospitals have never been captured so strikingly, with Kapadia and Ranabir Das, her chief collaborator and partner, using blue to evoke both the immense possibilities and the loneliness one can feel even amidst the chaos.

All We Imagine... also has what are now leitmotifs of a Kapadia film—poetic soliloquies delivered in hushed tones, a juxtaposition of ambiguous voices and lyrical imagery, vivid sound design and subtle political commentary. "I feel that a dissonance in sound and image creates more layering in the thinking of things," she says of her process, which *Film Comment* magazine has described as "artful docufiction". There's an elaborate method to how Kapadia arrives at her scripts. For *All We Imagine...*, she and a researcher spoke to almost 200 people over the course of two years, asking them about a migrant's experience of being in Mumbai for the first time. "I feel that my imagination is limited," she says. "I get a lot from talking to people, their mannerisms, gestures and how they might be in their private life... and knowing more about lived lives and seeing things." The artful bit extends even to the titles of her films, which read more like those for works in a gallery, be it the short *And What is the Summer Saying* (2018), *A Night of Knowing Nothing* (2021) or *All We Imagine...*, which she borrowed from one of her mother's paintings.

FAMILY MATTERS

Daughter of the famed artist Nalini Malani, a lot of Kapadia's aesthetic eye and the tenderness for her characters comes from her upbringing. Kapadia recalls tagging along with her sister and mum on weekly trips to secondhand book stalls in Flora Fountain and Kalbadevi to find "cheap art books" and children's books, some of which she still has. After school, Kapadia would be dropped to Malani's studio where she occupied herself with a "manoranjan box" filled with paints and random knick-knacks. "She [Nalini] had an eye to curate what I was looking at...," says Kapadia. "She was really encouraging of independent thought since a very young age."

Kapadia attributes her fascination with dreams, a recurring motif in her films, to her psychoanalyst father. "It was very much a part of our lives to wake up and talk about our dreams and their meaning. He'd have empathy if you had a certain kind of dream. I thought it was kind of ahead of its times," she says. It also helped that her father loved the city. "He knew the streets very well. Every time, it'd be an adventure. On Sunday, we'd go to Bhuleshwar and eat dhokla and jalebi. He was also a very good storyteller," says Kapadia.

Kapadia herself, though, spent a decade of her childhood and adolescence outside Mumbai, studying in Rishi Valley School in Andhra Pradesh. On her return at age 17, she studied at St Xavier's College, where most of her friends were from

THE BEST OF PAYAL

»ALL WE IMAGINE AS LIGHT *(2024)*

The first Indian film to compete in the main competition at the Cannes Film Festival in three decades, the Grand Prix-winning drama is Payal's wistful ode to Mumbai and a tale of female friendship, longing and desire

»A NIGHT OF KNOWING NOTHING *(2021)*

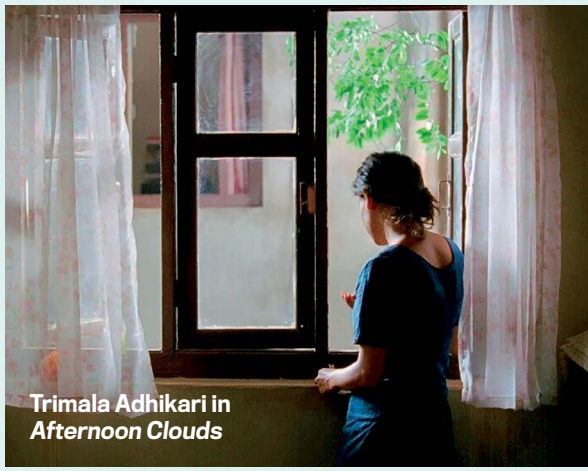
An "artful docufiction" about her film school, Payal uses found footage of the student protests between 2015 and 2019 against the voice of a young woman reading letters to her estranged lover. It won the L'Œil d'or (The Golden Eye), the best documentary award at Cannes

»AFTERNOON CLOUDS *(2018)*

"In my dream I saw so many clouds come into my home...," recounts a widow while yearn-



Kani Kusruti in *All We Imagine...*



Trimala Adhikari in *Afternoon Clouds*